

TAMIL NADU ORIGIN

Sambar

Tangy Lentil & Vegetable Stew

The Soul of the South Indian Table

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Sambar

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Sambar

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Royal Accident, A National Staple

Of all South India's dishes, sambar carries perhaps the most colorful origin story. As popular legend tells it, the dish was born in the royal kitchens of Thanjavur in the late 17th century, when Sambhaji — son of the Maratha king Shivaji — attempted to recreate his family's Maharashtrian amti (a tangy dal made with kokum or raw mango) using what was available in his Tamil kitchen. In place of kokum, the story goes, he used tamarind, and the result was an entirely new dish, said to have taken his name.

Historians treat this tale with some skepticism, since tamarind-based lentil stews likely existed in South India before this period, but the story remains beloved and widely repeated, and it captures something true about sambar: it is a dish born of adaptation, blending a North Deccan technique with distinctly Tamil ingredients and spice.

Whatever its exact origin, sambar became inseparable from Tamil Brahmin cooking by the 18th and 19th centuries, and from there spread across every South Indian state, each region adapting it — Andhra sambar leans spicier, Kerala's is often creamier with coconut, and Udupi hotels serve a thinner, lighter version that became the version most familiar to the rest of India.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Royal Accident, A National Staple, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A daily staple across Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Kerala, served with rice, idli, dosa, or vada. Central to temple food and festival meals, particularly at weddings and Tamil New Year feasts. Considered a complete, balanced dish in itself — protein from the lentils, vitamins from the vegetables, and the digestive benefits of tamarind and spice.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	25m	6	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker (for the dal) — or a covered pot with a longer simmer
- Wide, heavy-bottomed pan or kadai for cooking the vegetables
- Small pan for the tempering
- Fine sieve for straining tamarind pulp
- Spice grinder, if making sambar powder from scratch

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Sambar keeps refrigerated for 3–4 days and, like most stews, tastes even better the next day. It freezes well for up to 2 months — thaw overnight and reheat gently, adding a splash of water to loosen the consistency. Sambar powder, made in bulk, keeps in an airtight container for 2–3 months.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the base

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Toor dal (split pigeon pea)	¾ cup	150 g	¾ katori
Tamarind, seedless	2 tbsp	30 g	small lemon-size ball
Mixed vegetables (drumstick, pumpkin, brinjal, okra, carrot)	2½ cups, chopped	300 g	2½ katori
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	2 g	½ chammach
Water	as needed	as needed	as needed
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste
Jaggery	1 tsp	5 g	1 chammach

Sambar powder (or 3 tbsp store-bought)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Coriander seeds	2 tbsp	12 g	2 tbsp
Chana dal	1 tbsp	12 g	1 tbsp
Dried red chilies	4–5	4–5	4–5
Fenugreek seeds	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

Tempering (tadka)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee or oil	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 chammach
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Dried red chili	1	1	1
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Fresh tamarind can be replaced with 1 tbsp concentrated tamarind paste, adjusted to taste. Drumstick (moringa) can be hard to find outside India — frozen drumstick is widely sold at South Asian grocers, or simply omit and lean on pumpkin, carrot, and okra. Quality store-bought sambar powder (look for MTR or Aachi brand) is a completely acceptable shortcut.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Dal and Tamarind

01 COOK THE TOOR DAL

Rinse the toor dal and pressure cook with 2 cups / 480 ml water and a pinch of turmeric for 3–4 whistles, until completely soft and mashable. Whisk smooth once cooked.

02 PREPARE THE TAMARIND EXTRACT

Soak the tamarind in 1 cup / 240 ml warm water for 15 minutes, then squeeze and strain through a sieve to extract a thick, pulpy liquid. Discard the fibrous solids.



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Cooking the Dal and Tamarind, continued

03 TOAST AND GRIND THE SAMBAR POWDER

If making from scratch, dry roast the coriander seeds, chana dal, dried chilies, fenugreek, cumin, and curry leaves in a dry pan until fragrant and a shade darker, about 3–4 minutes. Cool completely, then grind to a fine powder.

Chef tip. roast each spice just until fragrant, not dark brown — over-roasting turns the powder bitter.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Sambar

04 COOK THE VEGETABLES IN TAMARIND WATER

In a wide pan, combine the chopped vegetables, tamarind extract, turmeric, and enough water to cover. Simmer until the vegetables are just tender, about 10–12 minutes — they should hold their shape, not disintegrate.

05 ADD THE DAL AND SAMBAR POWDER

Stir in the cooked dal and sambar powder. Add water as needed to reach a medium-thick, pourable consistency. Simmer for 8–10 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the raw tamarind smell fades and the flavors meld.

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Building the Sambar, continued



Cooking checkpoint. the sambar is ready when the surface takes on a light froth and the tamarind's sharp raw edge has mellowed into a rounded tang.

06 FINISH WITH JAGGERY AND SALT

Stir in the jaggery and salt to taste — the jaggery isn't meant to sweeten the dish, only to round out the tamarind's sourness.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Sambar, continued

07 ADD THE FINAL TEMPERING

Heat ghee or oil in a small pan. Add mustard seeds and let them pop, then the dried red chili, asafoetida, and curry leaves. Pour the sizzling tempering directly over the sambar and cover for a minute to trap the aroma.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding the sambar powder too early, before the vegetables are tender, mutes its aroma. Always add it after the vegetables have softened, in the last 10 minutes of cooking.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Poured generously over steamed rice with a spoon of ghee, the classic South Indian lunch.
- Served alongside idli, dosa, or vada for breakfast.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small individual bowl or katori alongside a dosa or idli platter.

Family Style

- A large serving bowl at the center of the table, ladled fresh over each plate as needed.

Modern Pairing

- Works beautifully over plain steamed rice bowls with a side of papad for a quick, complete weeknight meal.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Flavor Balancing

- A small piece of jaggery is essential — without it, the tamarind can taste one-dimensionally sour.
- Simmering the vegetables in the tamarind water first, before adding dal, keeps them from disintegrating.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Sambar powder can be made in a large batch monthly and stored airtight — most Tamil households do this rather than making it fresh each time.
- Sambar itself tastes better the next day, once the flavors have had time to deepen.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Hotel-style thin sambar, common at Udupi restaurants, uses more water and less dal — try a lighter ratio if you prefer a more brothy, drinkable style.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

145 kcal	7 g	22 g	3.5 g	6 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with vegetable and oil quantity.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Arachuvitta Sambar	made with a freshly ground coconut-spice paste rather than dry powder, for a richer, more textured stew.
Udupi Sambar	thinner and lighter, often with a touch of coconut, associated with Udupi hotel-style dosa service.
Andhra-Style Sambar	notably spicier, with more red chili and a stronger tamarind presence.
Kerala Sambar	leans creamier and slightly sweeter, often finished with coconut oil instead of ghee.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

My sambar tastes flat – what's missing?

Usually not enough sambar powder or an under-tempered tadka. Taste and adjust both before serving, and make sure the final tempering is added sizzling hot.

Can I make this without a pressure cooker?

Yes — simmer the dal in a covered pot for 30–40 minutes, topping up water as needed, until fully soft.

Is sambar vegan?

Yes, if you use oil instead of ghee for the tempering — everything else is naturally plant-based.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Toor dal	split pigeon pea lentil, the protein base of the stew.
Sambar powder	a roasted spice blend of coriander, chana dal, chilies, and fenugreek.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot oil or ghee, added at the end.
Drumstick	moringa pod, a long fibrous vegetable classic to sambar, eaten by scraping the flesh from the pod.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Sambar

15m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

BASE

Toor dal	150 g
Tamarind	30 g
Mixed vegetables	300 g
Turmeric powder	2 g
Water	as needed
Salt	to taste
Jaggery	5 g

SAMBAR POWDER (OR 3 TBSP STORE-BOUGHT)

Coriander seeds	12 g
Chana dal	12 g
Dried red chilies	4–5
Fenugreek seeds	1 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves

TEMPERING (TADKA)

Ghee or oil	15 ml
Mustard seeds	4 g
Dried red chili	1
Asafoetida	pinch
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves

METHOD

01 **Cook the toor dal.** Rinse the toor dal and pressure cook with 2 cups / 480 ml water and a pinch of turmeric for 3–4 whistles, until completely soft and mashable.

02 **Prepare the tamarind extract.** Soak the tamarind in 1 cup / 240 ml warm water for 15 minutes, then squeeze and strain through a sieve to extract a thick, pulpy liquid.

03 **Toast and grind the sambar powder.** If making from scratch, dry roast the coriander seeds, chana dal, dried chilies, fenugreek, cumin, and curry leaves in a dry pan until fragrant and a shade darker, about 3–4 minutes.

04 **Cook the vegetables in tamarind water.** In a wide pan, combine the chopped vegetables, tamarind extract, turmeric, and enough water to cover.

05 **Add the dal and sambar powder.** Stir in the cooked dal and sambar powder.

06 **Finish with jaggery and salt.** Stir in the jaggery and salt to taste — the jaggery isn't meant to sweeten the dish, only to round out the tamarind's sourness.

07 **Add the final tempering.** Heat ghee or oil in a small pan.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Toor dal	150 g	☐ Tamarind	30 g
☐ Mixed vegetables	300 g	☐ Turmeric powder	2 g
☐ Salt	to taste	☐ Jaggery	5 g
☐ Coriander seeds	12 g	☐ Chana dal	12 g
☐ Dried red chilies	4–5	☐ Fenugreek seeds	1 g
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Curry leaves	see recipe
☐ Ghee or oil	15 ml	☐ Mustard seeds	4 g
☐ Dried red chili	1	☐ Asafoetida	pinch

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